

Sri Krishna-chaitanya-charitamrita

"The Nectar of Sri Krishna Chaitanya's Acts" (Murari Gupta's Kadacha)

Murari Gupta

Translated from the Sanskrit into English

Translator's Note

Sri Krishna-chaitanya-charitamrita is the Sanskrit poem of Murari Gupta, a fellow-countryman and companion of

Sri Chaitanya and an eyewitness of his life in Navadvipa; tradition calls it Murari Gupta's *Kadacha* ("notes"). It

is the earliest biography of Mahaprabhu, drawn upon by Vrindavana Dasa, Kavikarnapura, Lochana Dasa and Krishnadasa

Kaviraja. The poem is divided into four *prakramas* (parts) and 78 *sargas* (cantos).

Source. The Sanskrit text has been reconstructed from three OCR copies: two scans of the edition of Haridasa

Shastri (Vrindavana) and the edition of Haridasa Dasa (Calcutta, 1945, Bengali script); readings were checked against

metre and grammar. Verse numbering follows Haridasa Shastri's edition. Only Murari Gupta's Sanskrit text has been

translated; the translations and commentaries of the editions were not used. Interpretation follows Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati.

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Prakrama One

Prakrama 1, Sarga 1. The Sequence of the Descent

Benediction; the appearance of Vishvambhara; Srivasa bids Murari tell of the Lord; Navadvipa and its devotees; Jagannatha Mishra

1. Glory to Him whose prowess is utterly pure, who shines like gold, whose eyes are wide as lotus petals, whose fine arms reach down to His knees, who in many ways dances in the rasa of devotion!
2. The son of Jagannatha, the Lord of the world, the origin of the world, the remover of the world's distress, the all-powerful, the protector in the Kali age, the remover of the burden of Kali — He was born of Shachi, bearing with Him devotion to Himself.
3. Hari, welcomed by the best of the twice-born in the lands of Navadvipa, giving joy to His parents and living happily at home, —
4. studied the Veda with its six limbs¹, dwelling in the house of His guru, devoted to serving him and pure in His vows. And He, Hari, called Vishvambhara, so that the righteous might follow the dharma of this age, —
5. enjoined the kirtana of Hari, remembering that it is supremely dear to Hari and is the highest goal of human life. Performing the rite for His ancestors in Gaya, in the lands marked by Hari's feet, He Himself —
6. from the mere treasure of remembering Himself, became stunned with love, the hair of His body standing on end. Then, at the word of a bodiless voice², He returned to His own home.
7. The Lord, surrounded by the foremost of His devotees — He whose form was full of ripened love, the crusher of the lion-like Danavas — rejoiced in the happiness of the kirtana of Hari and of holy talks about Him.
8. Then, so that thirsting ears might plunge into the fame of Him whose glory is generous — a nectar for the ears of the virtuous — one whose eyes trembled with tears of joy took up this splendid, auspicious and true narrative³.
9. A devotee named Srivasa, the sun that makes the lotus of the twice-born race bloom, said to Sri Murari: "Tell here a new, holy account of the life of Hari." Accepting his command and bowing to him again and again with openly joined palms, Murari himself began to tell the glory of Sriman Chaitanya, which takes away the stain of Kali.
10. Then Murari, the physician's son, reflected: "How shall I tell the auspicious story of Chaitanya, so rich in meaning,
11. which even Vachaspati⁴ himself cannot tell? Yet it is fitting to carry out the command of a Vaishnava — so my mind resolves.
12. It shines ever pure through the treasure of remembering Krishna; the Vaishnava's command will surely bear fruit, and not otherwise."
13. Having said this, he began to tell the story enriched with devotion to Bhagavan — for dharma, wealth and desire, for liberation, and for devotion to Vishnu.
14. I bow to Chaitanya — the unborn, the primeval, the four-armed, bearing conch, mace, lotus and disc — to Hari, whose chest is marked with the sign of Shrivatsa, with a gem upon His fair forehead, finely clad.

15. I shall tell something of the stories of Bhagavan for the delight of the virtuous. And if some slip should occur, then to correct it here is the task of the greatest souls, who do good to others: they alone are the authority in this.
16. In the holy place known as Navadvipa, supremely Vaishnava, there lived brahmanas — saintly, peaceful, Vaishnavas, born in good families,
17. great, skilled in rites, all masters of the meaning of the scriptures; and there are also many other people there — physicians, shudras and merchants.
18. All of them are devoted to their own duties and pure, all live by learning; all of them there have vowed themselves to God — in that place which is like the abode of Vaikuntha.
19. There shone Srivasa, an intoxicated bee sporting at the lotus feet of Hari: moist with love, his arms flung up⁵, ever eager, he sings of the Lord in the rapture of the highest rasa. There too was Gopinatha⁶, foremost of the twice-born: as soon as the name of Krishna reached his ears, he, intoxicated, wept aloud again and again and danced beyond measure, his hands quivering in rhythm.
20. There shone the master, the great soul, the excellent Sri Advaita — radiant as the rising morning sun, skilled in awakening the lotuses of the hearts of the wise; like the moon born of the ocean of compassion, the very embodiment of cooling the burning in people's hearts; unsurpassed in loving meditation, rich in the fine gift of the art of dance, a teacher of the art of the highest rasa.
21. There shone brightly the teacher Chandrashekhara, endowed with every virtue, the king of the twice-born⁷; at the name of Krishna the hair of his body stood on end, and he was wet with streaming tears.
22. There, when the sage Haridasa dances, the Lord of the world, out of love for His servant, joyfully watches that dance together with the hosts of gods led by Mahesha, moving through the sky.
23. There flows the river born from Vishnu's foot, swift and wholly moist with compassion, who, vying with the Yamuna, daughter of the Sun, and with the Sarayu, bore Hari shining like gold⁸.
24. In that place lived Jagannatha, like the moon in the ocean of the twice-born race, a teacher of the Vedas, endowed with all virtues, equal to Brihaspati. Pure in mind through the mighty yoga of meditation on Krishna's feet, moist with love, he grew swiftly like the crescent of the new moon.

Thus ends the first sarga, "The Sequence of the Descent," of the first prakrama of the great poem "Sri Chaitanya-charita."

1. The six angas (auxiliary disciplines) of the Veda: phonetics, ritual, grammar, etymology, metrics and astronomy.
2. The "bodiless voice" (asharira vak) is a voice from the sky, heard without a visible speaker.
3. The subject is not named; to judge from the next verse, it is the poet himself, Murari Gupta.
4. Vachaspati ("lord of speech") is Brihaspati, the preceptor of the gods, the model of eloquence.
5. The beginning of the second line of this verse is damaged in the sources; "his arms flung up" is a reading restored by the metre.
6. Gopinatha is a brahmana of Navadvipa; apparently Gopinatha Acharya, who later appears in Nilachala.
7. "King of the twice-born" (dvija-raj) is also a poetic name of the moon — a play on the name Chandrashekhara ("Crowned with the Moon").
8. On the banks of the Yamuna Krishna played, on the banks of the Sarayu (in Ayodhya) Rama; the Ganga at Navadvipa has received Gaura.

Prakrama 1, Sarga 2. Narada's Sorrow

Jagannatha Mishra and Shachi; the birth of Vishvarupa; Damodara Pandita's question; Narada sees the earth gripped by Kali

1. Then his guru, knower of the truth, conferred on him, who knew the meaning of all the scriptures, the title "Shriman Mishra Purandara"¹.
2. Once the illustrious and great-minded Nilambara, called Chakravarti, summoned this learned man of noble family, the best of the righteous,
3. and gave him his daughter Shachi in marriage — he, the support of his line²; and having won her, Mishra prospered, like Purandara having won Shachi³.
4. From then on, as he lived at home, his dharma grew — through hospitality, propitiatory rites, purifications, and the fruits of regular and optional rites.
5. In the course of time eight lovely daughters were born to him one after another, and by fate they all died. Shachi —
6. her mind burning with the grief of a mother's love, took refuge in Hari in her heart, praying for a son; and the illustrious Mishra performed a sacrifice to the ancestors.
7. After some time he obtained a son like a son of the gods, and Jagannatha rejoiced like a poor man who has found a treasure.
8. The father gave the illustrious boy the name Vishvarupa. In a very short time that great soul studied
9. the Vedas and the science of logic, and became known as excellent, endowed with true yoga. He was all-knowing, wise, peaceful, and a benefactor of all.
10. Always intent on meditating on Hari, he did not turn his mind to the objects of the senses, and was ceaselessly intoxicated with tasting the rasa of the Srimad-Bhagavatam.
11. As his younger brother the Lord Himself was born — the unborn source of the world — just as Upendra, the younger brother of Indra, was born the son of Kashyapa and Aditi⁴.
12. He Himself made the three worlds devoted to the sankirtana of Hari; having lived in the foremost of holy places, called Purushottama,
13. practising devotion to Hari and teaching it to the people, having tasted the sweetness of Sri Vrindavana and giving the people to taste it,
14. having delivered the whole world — He, honoured by the dwellers of Vaikuntha, joyfully went to His very own abode, full of great splendour.
15. Hearing of this wonder, the brahmachari who had conquered his senses, intoxicated with the stories of Sri Chaitanya — Sri Damodara Pandita⁵ — said:
16. "Tell the divine, wondrous story that purifies the world, by hearing which people are freed from samsara and from dreadful sin.
17. Through it the supreme treasures of love for the lotus feet of Sri Krishna arise in all people; so tell the story of Hari.
18. For what reason was He, the all-powerful Lord of all, born on earth? What did He, the Lord of the worlds, do here?
19. Please tell of His auspicious and blessed deeds — for relieving the distress of the worlds, and for the love of the very great souls."
20. Hearing these words of the great-souled pandita, Murari was pleased and said: "Listen!
21. Well, O best of the twice-born, I shall tell you as far as I am able — in brief, for even Bhargava⁶ could not tell it in full.

22. Once Narada, the righteous soul, foremost of the Vaishnavas, of great power, radiant as the full moon — in the land called Bharata —
23. white as the peak of Kailasa, adorned with a fine girdle, wearing a deerskin, a portion of Vishnu, dear to all people —
24. was wandering through the vault of the sky for the good of all, joyfully sounding his Mahati⁷, which sings forth the name of Hari.
25. 'Where shall I see a Vaishnava? There I shall now dwell' — thinking thus, he surveyed this earth with his mind,
26. and saw that Kali, the friend of sin, had muddied the wide earth with filth, and that the earth-cow herself was in the hands of the mlechchhas and drained by cruel taxes⁸.
27. And he saw there people beset by sins and diseases, given to slandering others, deceitful, short-lived and emaciated;
28. he saw kings skilled in sin, shudras, villainous Yavanas, mlechchhas given to forbidden deeds, robbing their subjects of all they had,
29. and even men learned in scripture — proud, and reviling the saints. Seeing all these many kinds of people, Narada fell to pondering.

Thus ends the second sarga, "Narada's Sorrow," of the first prakrama of the great poem "Sri Krishna-chaitanya-charita."

1. Purandara ("Destroyer of Strongholds") is a name of Indra; hence the wordplay in v. 3, since Indra's consort is also named Shachi.
2. The epithet kulakricchadah is the same in all the sources, but its meaning is unclear; the translation is conjectural.
3. That is, like Indra, who won his consort Shachi.
4. Upendra is Vishnu as Vamana, born of the sage Kashyapa and Aditi as Indra's younger brother.
5. From this verse the poem is framed as a dialogue: Damodara Pandita asks, and Murari tells.
6. Bhargava is Shukra, the preceptor of the asuras, famed for his wisdom.
7. The Mahati is Narada's vina.
8. A play on words: go means both "earth" and "cow"; kara means both "tax" and "ray" (the earth is parched as if by scorching rays). Mlechchhas and Yavanas are foreigners outside Vedic dharma; the Muslim rulers of Bengal are meant.

Prakrama 1, Sarga 3. Narada's Inquiry

Narada goes to Vaikuntha; the vision of Vaikuntha and of Krishna; Narada pleads for the world perishing in Kali; the Lord agrees to descend

1. "In the first twilight of Kali¹ this earth has sunk (into sin). For all who are scorched by sin the name of Hari is the healing elixir;
2. it surely becomes a deliverer — for all except those who hate the Vaishnavas: except the self-conceited and except the revilers of the Vaishnavas.
3. But those dull-witted ones who would revile the name of Krishna and His forms, saying, 'They are not eternal'² — for them there is only hell.
4. What remedy can there be here?" Having pondered this, the sage, pure of mind, a treasury of compassion, went to the supreme abode called Vaikuntha.
5. And the sage saw Vaikuntha, sung by the three Vedas, the undivided abode, which by its own radiance has dispelled the dust (of rajas) in every quarter — and he attained a state beyond the gunas.

6. There swarms of bees sing Hari's fame among rows of lotuses; it is adorned with ponds lovely with jewelled banks and fragrant with hanging creepers;
7. in it are ruby houses with turrets adorned with strings of pearls from the heads of lordly elephants³; in it are trees that bear in every season; it resounds with the song of birds and is rich in paths of moonstone.
8. There he saw the unborn, the primeval one, attended by Shri — He whose locks are lit by the radiance of a gleaming crown, whose eyes surpass blooming celestial lotuses, whose fair, shining face the very moon worships;
9. whose cheeks are graced by gleaming great earrings, whose neck is fine as a conch, whose garments shine like gold — Krishna, with four arms like door-bars, like a blue mountain peak with wish-fulfilling trees;
10. resplendent with golden armlets and other ornaments, with strings of pearls and fine golden cords; He whose hips shine with a cloth bound by a net of little bells; He whose feet are beautiful lotuses.
11. Inhaling the charming fragrance of His lotus feet, the sage — with tears of joy, his hair standing on end — at once fell to the ground near Krishna like a rod, as if senseless.
12. Then the grateful Lord at once stretched out His hand, the radiance of whose nails was variegated by jewelled rings, joyfully touched the sage's head and, His face graced by a gentle smile, spoke charmingly:
13. "Rise, O son of the Self-born⁴, O sage, O great soul! Whatever you tell Me today, that I shall do for you. For My time has come of itself — the time when, in the ages, the righteous must practise dharma."
14. Then Hari, wholly devoted to the greatest souls, raised up the best of the great rishis and at once showed him a seat, and at Hari's command the sage sat down.
15. Then Bhagavan asked: "O sage, why have you come here to Me? What is your wish? Though I am complete, let Me do your task, O holy one: the deeds of the great are for the good of others."
16. Hearing such nectarean words from Krishna, the ocean of the nectar of mercy, words that sounded like a rain-laden cloud, and (encouraged) by Hari's glance full of smiles, the sage said: "I bow to You! Protect the suffering worlds!
17. Now, O mighty one, the earth is wasting away in distress, bearing people laden with floods of sin. And all the people, bitten by the time of Kali, delight in sin and have abandoned talk of You.
18. Protect them, O Master: apart from You they have no other protector from hell, no other good refuge. Having considered this, act, O Lord of all worlds: You Yourself are the good refuge, O Lord, and no other."
19. Having heard these words of the sage, Hari, though He knew all, said: "What shall I do? By what means can peace come? Tell Me." And the son of the Self-born spoke to Him again:
20. "Descend Yourself, cooling as a hundred moons, in a lineage of brahmanas, in a good family of the Vatsya line⁵; win renown as 'the son of Jagannatha,' and bring welfare to the earth.
21. What You did, O Bhagavan, in the forms of Rama and others — the slaying of sinful Rakshasas and Danavas and the like — that is not to be done here: purify the minds of men.
22. 'If I kill those who have fallen into the demoniac state, where then will the world be?' — resolving thus in Your own mind, make Your glory known, and may the people be happy.
23. And there too, together with Rudra, the foremost of sages would descend to help You"⁶. "So be it," Hari said to the divine rishi; and he, bowing, at once departed joyfully.

Thus ends the third sarga, "Narada's Inquiry," of the first prakrama of the great poem "Sri Krishna-chaitanya-charita."

1. The "twilight" (sandhya) is the opening period of a yuga; the Kali age has only just begun.
 2. The Lord's name and form are eternal and not material; to call them non-eternal is an offence.
 3. According to poetic convention, pearls form in the heads of lordly elephants.
 4. Narada is the son of Brahma, the Self-born (Svayambhu).
 5. Vatsya is the brahmana clan (gotra) to which Jagannatha Mishra belonged.
 6. Which gods and sages descended together with the Lord is told in the next sarga.
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Prakrama 1, Sarga 4. On the Descents

The Lord's companions as portions of the Lord, of gods and of sages; the story of Haridasa; the two kinds of avatara: the avatars of the ages and the avatars for a particular purpose

1. Having heard all this, Sri Damodara Pandita, greatly pleased, said: "Tell, then, the story of Nrihari¹.
2. Who, in these descents, came down to the earth? And of how many kinds are the descents? Tell me of them in order."
3. Hearing these words of the foremost of the twice-born, Sri Murari said respectfully and with great affection: "Listen!
4. Now I shall tell you of something else — of the descent of Hari's own portions: of the devotees renowned as pure devotees, who are forms of the Lord.
5. First was born the best of the twice-born, the master Sri Madhava Puri. A portion of the Lord, dividing in two, (appeared as him) and as Advaita Acharya, endowed with good qualities².
6. The disciple of them both was the divine Chandrashekhara, a portion of the Moon; of great fame, he is renowned on earth as Acharyaratna.
7. Sriman Srivasa Pandita was born as a portion of Sri Narada; Sri Mukunda of the Vaidya (physician) caste, the fine singer, was a portion of a Gandharva.
8. Sriman Sri Haridasa was a portion of a sage. Hear how this was once told by a brahmana bitten by a snake³.
9. Formerly there lived in Dravida, in a Vaishnava holy place, an illustrious, excellent sage named Rama, a great ascetic, who loved his son dearly.
10. His son washed tulasi leaves and placed them in a clean vessel, but they fell on the ground, and without washing them again
11. he gave them to his father; and he, the great sage named Sri Rama, offered them to Bhagavan. For that reason he was born in a Yavana (Muslim) family.
12. He is righteous, wise, peaceful and versed in all knowledge; he is also a portion of Brahma⁴ — and therefore the illustrious Haridasa is, beyond doubt, a true devotee.
13. The Avadhuta Nityananda, of great power, the greatest, was born as a portion of Baladeva; he is the great yogi, the Lord Himself.
14. I do not venture to describe his family, character and deeds: even Brihaspati himself, in a hundred years,
15. could not tell of them — what then of others, of us petty creatures! He is the second form of Sri Krishna, dear to Gauranga as life itself.

16. And many others — hundreds of gods and eminent sages — were born on earth as portions; I do not venture to enumerate them.
17. Next: it is declared that the descents of the Purusha are of two kinds. The first is the avatara of the age (yuga-avatara); the second appears for a particular task.
18. Those are called avataras of the ages who appear in age after age and establish dharma. Hear of them in order.
19. In the Satya age meditation alone brings a man to the goal. For this purpose the White One descended, four-armed, with matted locks;
20. like a thousand moons, a sage always absorbed in meditation, He became the teacher of meditation for all living beings.
21. In the Treta age the one dharma that achieves every aim is sacrifice. Then Yajna Himself was born, with the sacrificial ladles and the other implements.
22. Together with brahmanas who performed sacrifice, He, Janardana, the enjoyer of sacrifice, the Victorious One, Himself performed sacrifice and taught it to all the people.
23. In the Dvapara age worship is ordained for attaining the goal of life. Knowing this, Vishnu Himself appeared in the form of Prithu⁵.
24. Righteous, He performed worship and instructed the people in it, and the minds of all turned to worship.
25. But in Kali the highest good is kirtana — the dharma that benefits all, full of all powers, directly bestowing the highest bliss.
26. Having resolved thus in His mind, Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu Himself was born on earth, bringing happiness to the saintly.
27. Full of joy, He Himself performed kirtana and caused others to perform it. These are the avataras of the ages. Hear now of the others — those who descend for a particular task.
28. As the Fish — the rescue of the Vedas; as the Tortoise — the bearing of Mount Mandara; as the Boar — the lifting up of the earth; as Narasimha — the tearing apart (of Hiranyakashipu);
29. as Vamana He took for Himself the sovereignty of the worlds from the king of the Danavas; and Bhargava⁶ conquered the earth, defeating the arrogant kings,
30. and Vishnu, the sole deliverer of the world, gave that earth to a brahmana. As Sri Rama He slew Ravana, and the world was filled with His glory.
31. And in the descent of Srīman Krishna, Hari Himself, endowed with all powers, removed the burden of the earth.
32. As the Buddha the Supreme Bhagavan bewildered (people) regarding the Vedas, and in the form of Kalki He destroyed the mlechchhas.
33. Such are the many deeds of the many-formed Nrihari; the great rishis have described these avataras who descend for a particular task."

Thus ends the fourth sarga, "On the Descents" (Avatāranukarāṇa), of the first prakrama of the great poem "Śrī Kṛṣṇa-chaitanya-charitamṛta."

1. Nrihari ("Man-Hari") is usually a name of Nṛsiṃha; here, as in v. 33, it names the Lord in general.
2. The sense is that a single portion of the Lord appeared in two ways — as Madhavendra Puri and as Advaita Acharya.
3. The brahmana's account itself is not given in the poem; Murari relates only its substance (vv. 9–11).
4. According to tradition, Haridasa is a portion of Brahma, who appeared as a devotee to atone for an offence.

5. The avatara of the Dvapara age is usually named otherwise; here Murari Gupta names Prithu, the king who first established the order of worship.
6. Bhargava is Parashurama, the descendant of Bhrigu.